

The Life of Saint Tekle Haimanot

By Dn Yonnas · Saints · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

The great Ethiopian saint whose name means 'Plant of Faith' — monk, hermit, missionary, and founder of Debre Libanos. The lesson follows his birth to righteous parents after years of barrenness, his call by the Archangel Michael, the miracle of the six wings at Debre Damo, his evangelization of pagan Damot, and his final vow of standing in prayer for seven years.

Lesson Objectives

- Tell the life of St. Tekle Haimanot from childhood to repose
- Explain his mission to Damot and the founding of Debre Libanos (c. 1284)
- Draw lessons from his union of apostolic mission and ascetic devotion

Key Bible Verses

Psalm 1:3 — "like a tree planted by the rivers of water"

Matthew 19:21 — "If you want to be perfect, go, sell what you have... and come, follow Me"

2 Timothy 4:7 — "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race"

Main Teaching Points

- Born to Priest Tsega Ze'ab and Egzi'e Haraya after years of faithful prayer
- Called as a young deacon by the Archangel Michael to renounce the world
- Given six wings when the rope broke at Debre Damo — apostle and ascetic in one
- Evangelized the pagan kingdom of Damot, beginning with its prince
- Founded Debre Libanos, the spiritual capital of Ethiopian monasticism
- Stood in prayer for seven years on one leg — the triumph of spirit over flesh

Key Terms

- **Gädl** — The written 'spiritual combat' or life-story of a saint, e.g., the Gädlä Täklä Haymanot.
- **Debre Libanos** — The great monastery founded by St. Tekle Haimanot in Shewa, c. 1284.
- **Monasticism** — The consecrated life of prayer, fasting, and renunciation for the Kingdom of God.
- **Hermit** — A monk who withdraws into solitude for unceasing prayer.

Discussion & Reflection

- What does his name, 'Plant of Faith,' teach about how faith grows?
- Why did monasticism become so central to Ethiopian Christianity?
- What 'small vow' of discipline could you keep this month in his spirit?